

20TH CENTURY DICTATOR Born 1889 Died 1945

# Adolf Hitler

“When starting and waging a war, it is **not right** that matters, **but victory.**”

HITLER, 22 AUGUST 1939

**W**orld War I was the pivotal event in the life of German dictator Adolf Hitler. Before the war, this son of a minor official in the Austro-Hungarian Empire was a failed artist, nursing fantasies of greatness but in reality living an aimless, embittered existence on the margins of society. Four years serving on the Western Front put Hitler in touch with the shared experience of millions of Germans: the participation in modern warfare at its most destructive and of a defeat so painful that it had to be met with denial.

## Hitler the soldier

This image shows Hitler as a corporal in the German Army in April 1915. As a “runner” carrying messages to the frontline trenches, he was wounded three times. In 1918, he was awarded the Iron Cross (right) for bravery under fire.



Like many other ex-servicemen, Hitler found it impossible to demobilize mentally, regarding himself as a frontline soldier (“*Frontkämpfer*”) for the rest of his life.

## Speaker and politician

Hitler had no particular interest in politics before or during World War I, nor had he expressed any particular dislike of Jews. But amid the political and social chaos of postwar Germany, he adopted views by which many Germans explained away the collapse of their country: that the war had been lost through a “stab in the back” by socialists and Jews, and that Germany



## Mein Kampf

Hitler wrote his autobiographical political statement *Mein Kampf* (My Struggle) while in prison for nine months for his part in the Munich Putsch of 1923 (see right). Published in 1925, the book expressed his hatred of Judaism and Communism and his ambition to establish a German empire in the east.



## The Führer

Nazi propaganda photos depicted Hitler as the towering leader—führer—of his people. He was totally convinced by his personal myth, seeing himself as a “man of destiny” leading the German people to greatness.

